NORTHVIEW STORIES

01

ODDS & ASSETS

THE LONG PLAY



ONE BET. TEN YEARS. A SECOND CHANCE.

A YOUNG ADULT GRAPHIC NOVEL

ODDS & ASSETS / ISSUE 01

THE LONG PLAY

A win can last a night.
A choice can follow you for years.

Marcus wants a shortcut to freedom. One reckless decision costs his family more than money. Rebuilding his life will take something a winning streak never taught him: patience.

01 **EASY MONEY** — The rush. The risk. The fallout. — 03

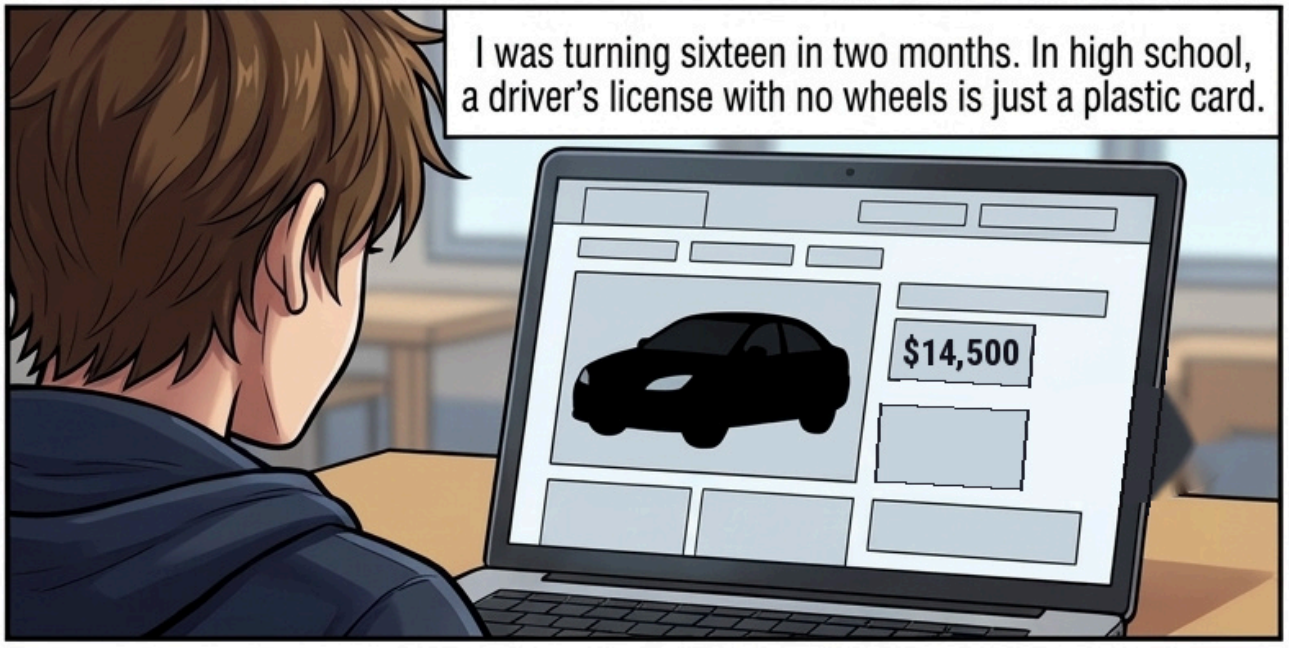
02 **THE RESET** — A mentor. A plan. A different path. — 10

03 **THE LONG GAME** — Small steps, repeated for years. — 17

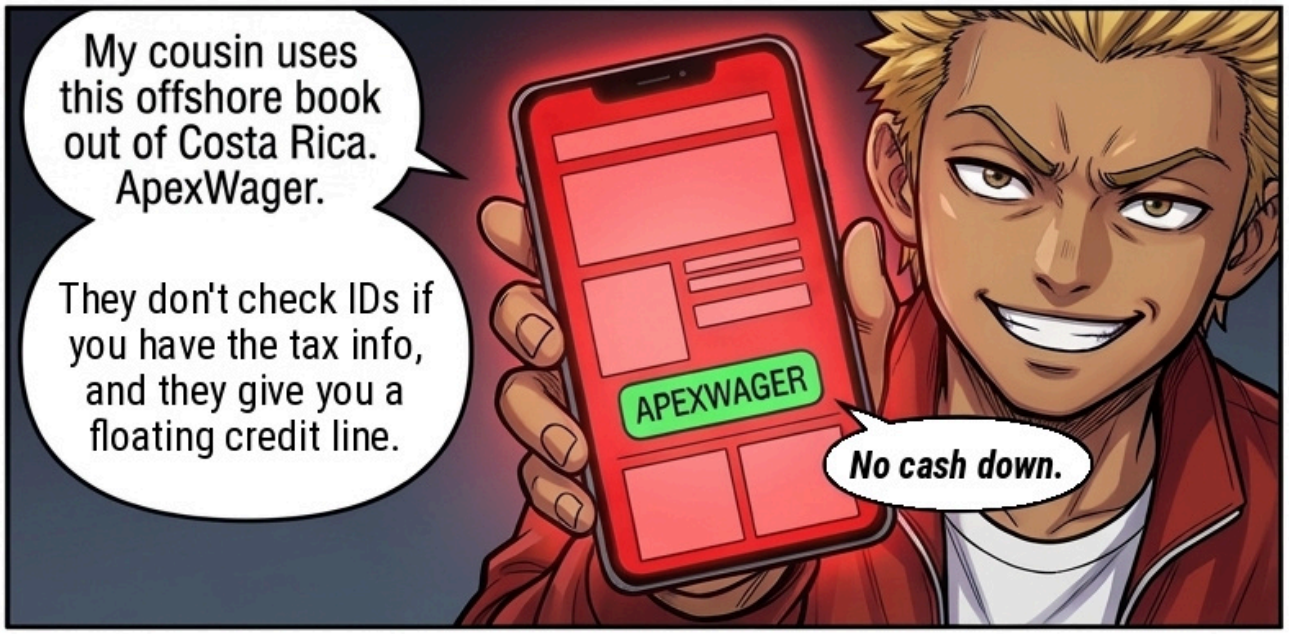
04 **FULL CIRCLE** — Back to where it started. — 21

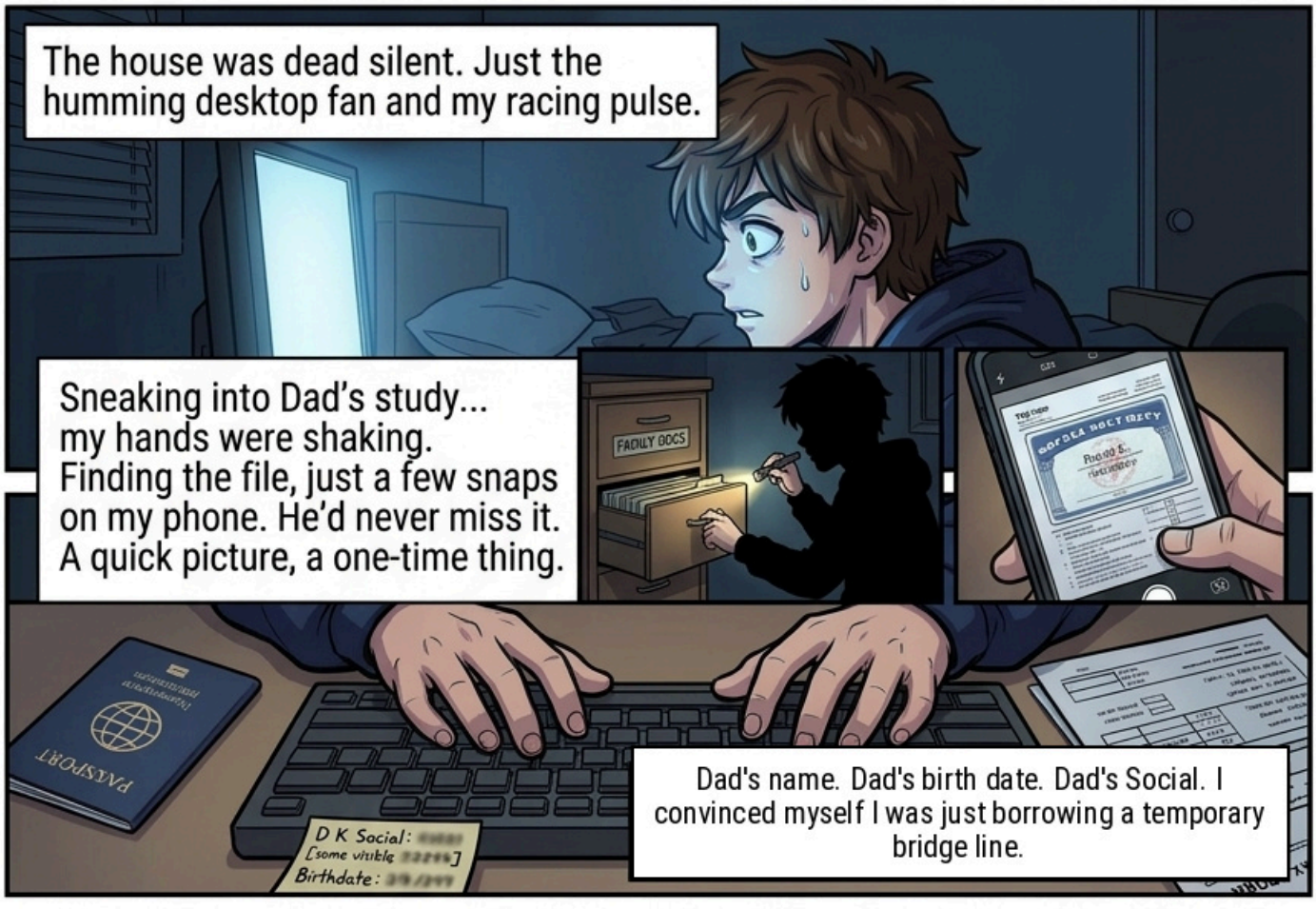
A fictional story about choices, consequences, and rebuilding trust.
Read panels from left to right, then top to bottom.

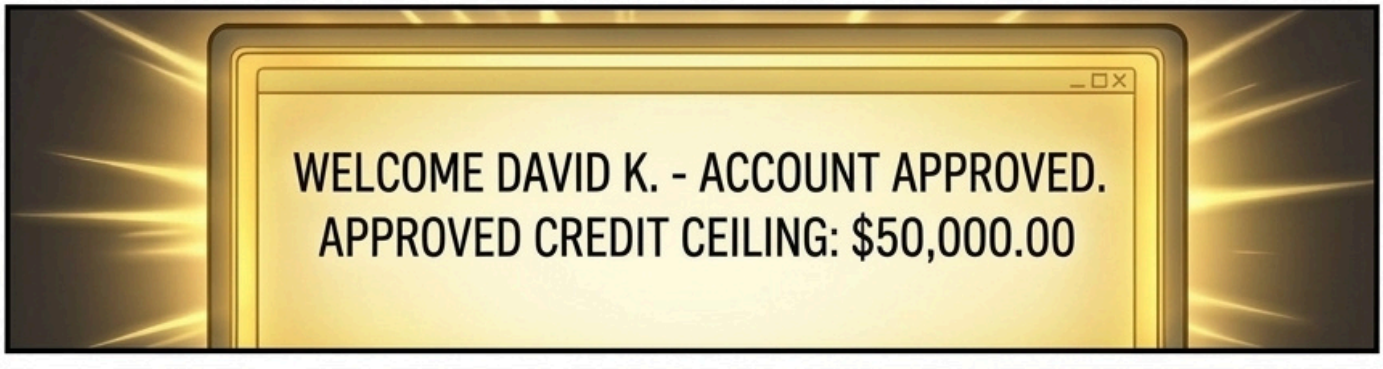

He hit it from half court! Marc, your parlay cashed!
It started as a joke. Twenty bucks on basketball, thirty on soccer.
PROFIT: +$140.00
When you don't know the math, luck feels like genius.
My gut hadn't missed in three weeks.
Why work four hours after school when a phone tap doubles your money?


I was turning sixteen in two months. In high school, a driver's license with no wheels is just a plastic card.
$14,500


...Clean ride, Marc. But at fifteen bucks an hour washing dishes...
...you'll be twenty before you save fourteen grand.
Yeah. Summer jobs aren't gonna cut it.


My cousin uses this offshore book out of Costa Rica. ApexWager.
They don't check IDs if you have the tax info, and they give you a floating credit line.
APEXWAGER
No cash down.


The house was dead silent. Just the humming desktop fan and my racing pulse.
Sneaking into Dad's study... my hands were shaking. Finding the file, just a few snaps on my phone. He'd never miss it. A quick picture, a one-time thing.
FAMILY DOCS
PASSPORT
D K Social: [some visible]
Birthdate:
Dad's name. Dad's birth date. Dad's Social. I convinced myself I was just borrowing a temporary bridge line.

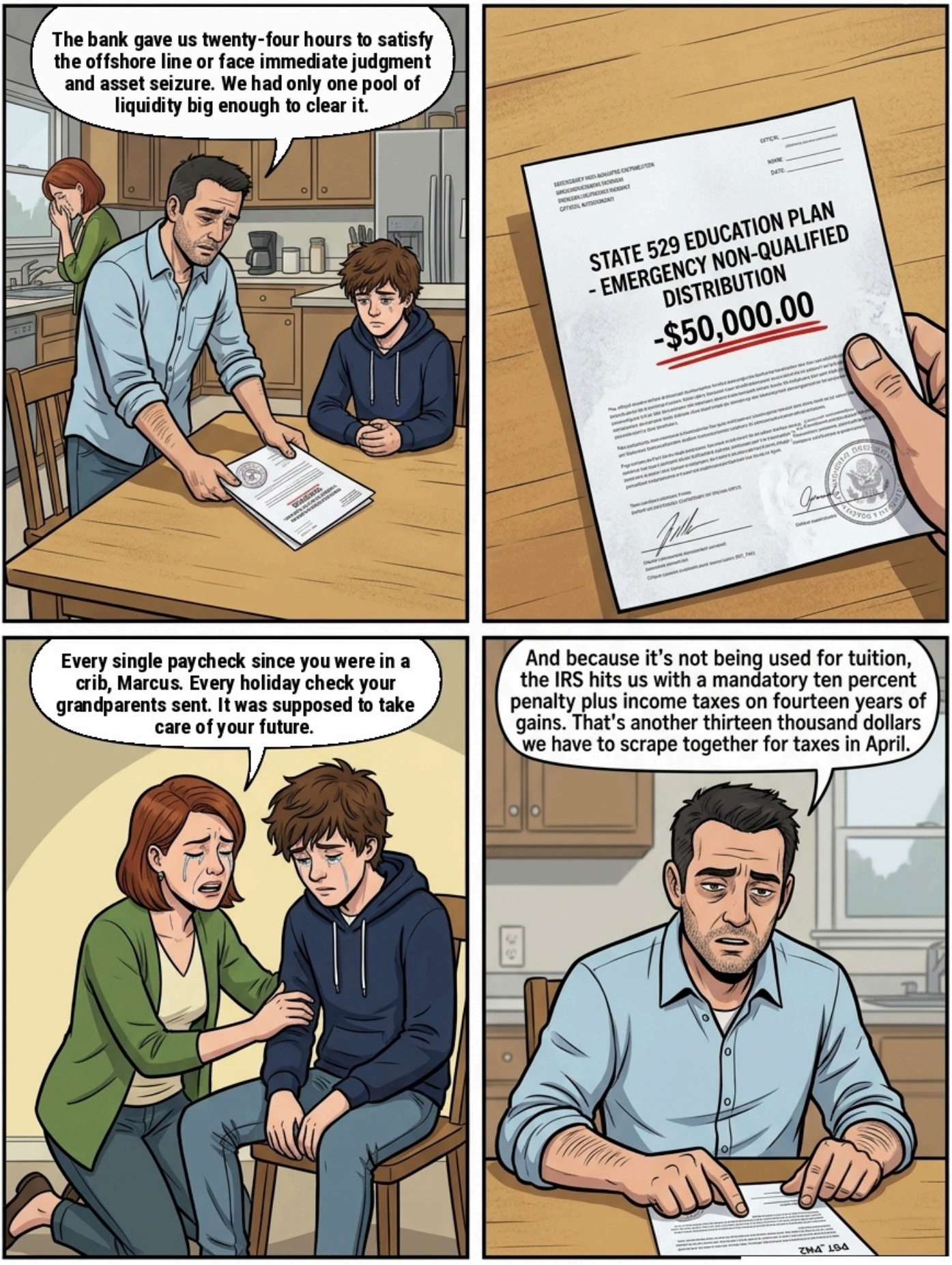

WELCOME DAVID K. - ACCOUNT APPROVED.
APPROVED CREDIT CEILING: $50,000.00

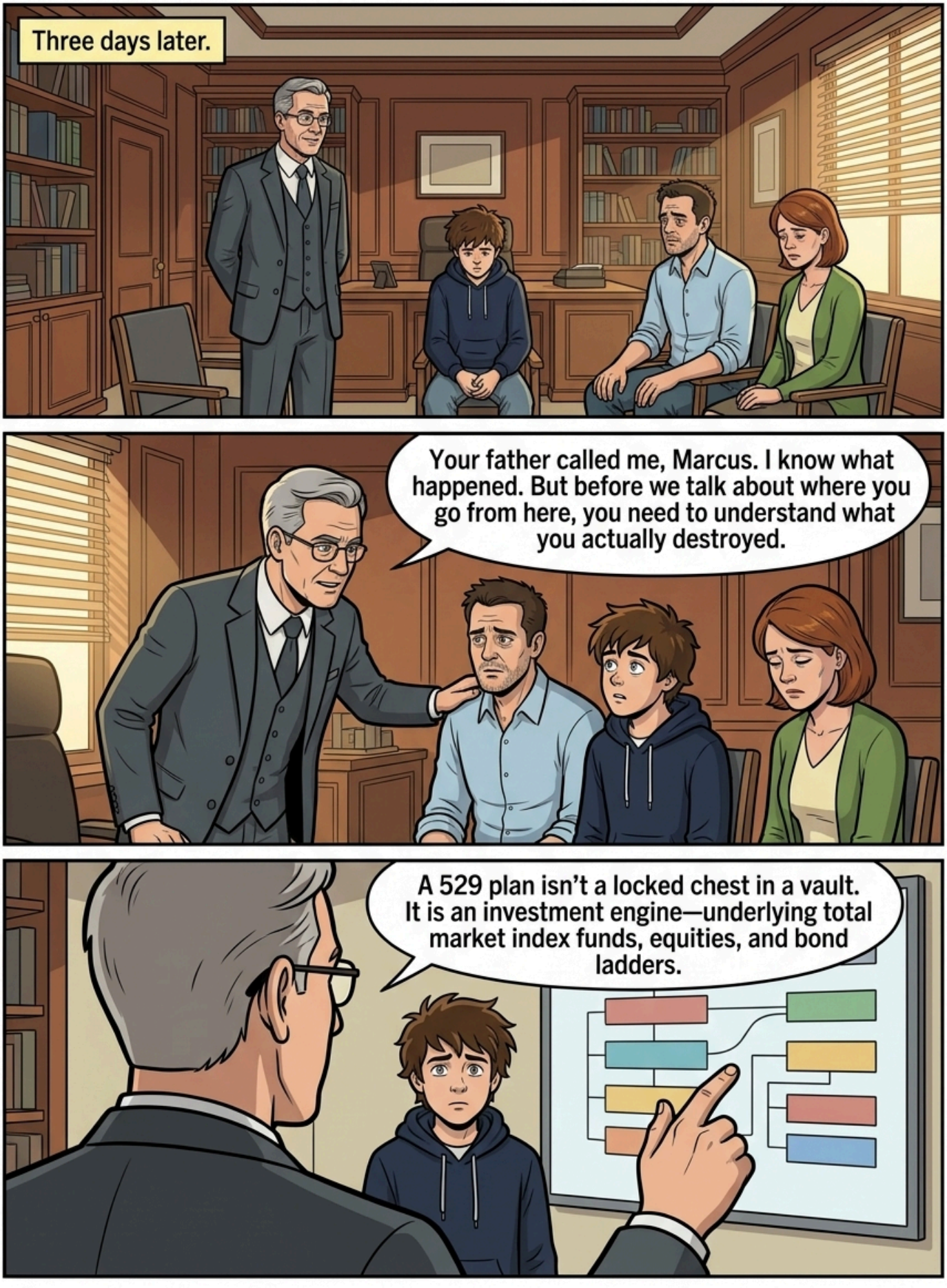

One bet on the heavy favorite spread. Win sixty grand. Buy the coupe cash. Close the book Monday morning. Dad will never know.

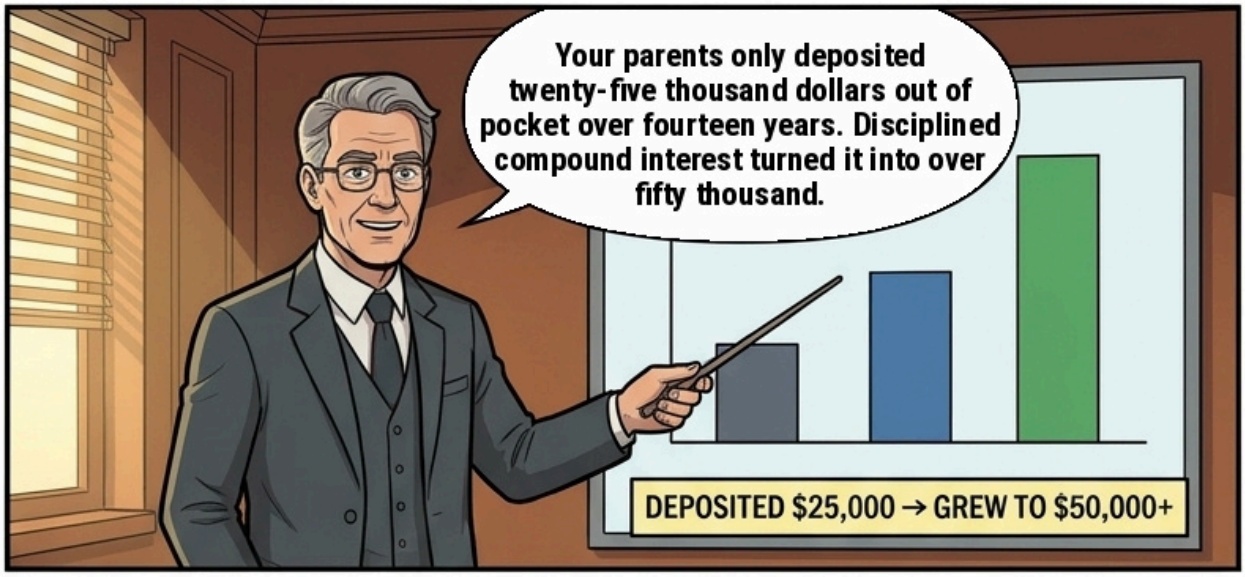

Please!!!
MY BET
4TH 1:12 · 87-87
SLIP!
TWEET!
No, no, no... pass the ball outside... shoot the three!
0:00
BZZZZT!

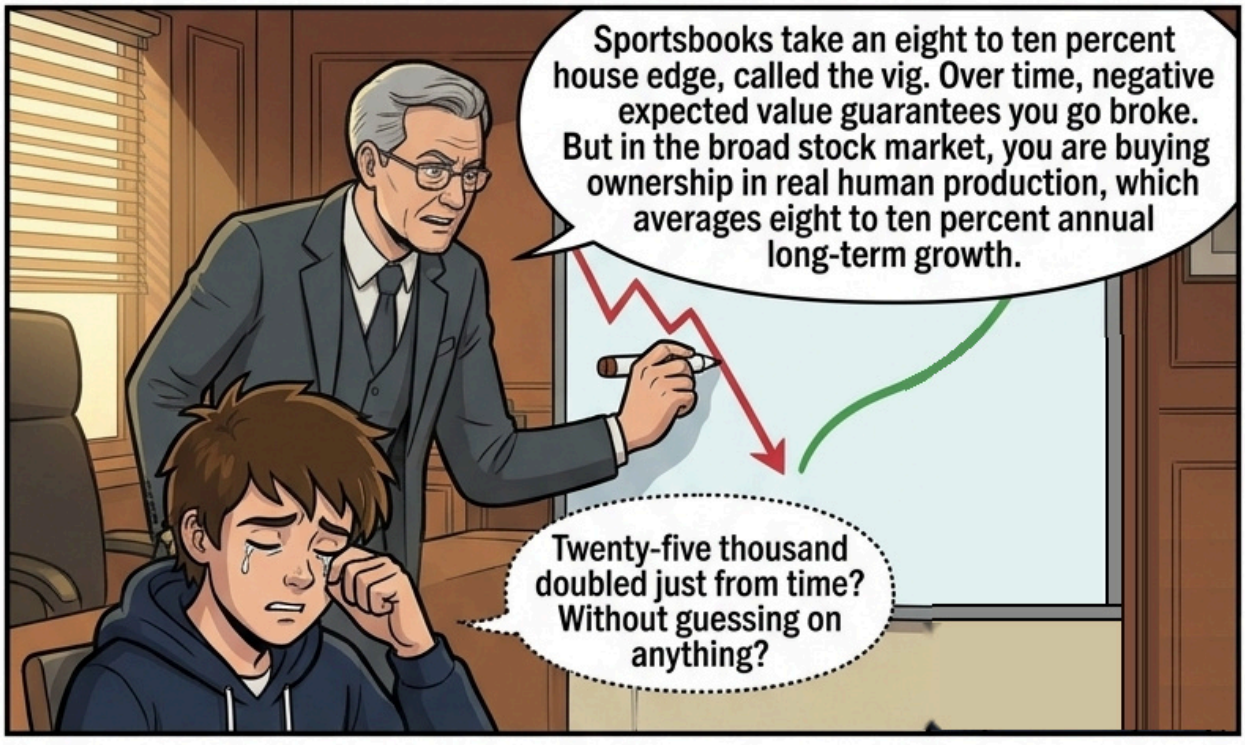

NOOO!
?!?
FINAL SCORE: 88-87
(FAVORITE FAILS SPREAD)
BET LOSS: -$50,000.00
STATUS: DELINQUENT
RECONCILIATION DEMAND
TRANSMITTED TO LINKED ASSETS
How...?
3:15 AM
6:30 AM
CRASH!
MARCUS!!
GET DOWN HERE!


Our checking account is frozen. An international collections enforcement firm hit our bank with a fifty-thousand-dollar claim under my Social Security number.
Tell me right now what you did.
I was just trying to buy a car... I thought the bet was guaranteed... I'm so sorry, Dad...
Guaranteed? You put our home, our credit, and our life on the line for a ball game?


The bank gave us twenty-four hours to satisfy the offshore line or face immediate judgment and asset seizure. We had only one pool of liquidity big enough to clear it.
STATE 529 EDUCATION PLAN - EMERGENCY NON-QUALIFIED DISTRIBUTION
-$50,000.00
Every single paycheck since you were in a crib, Marcus. Every holiday check your grandparents sent. It was supposed to take care of your future.
And because it's not being used for tuition, the IRS hits us with a mandatory ten percent penalty plus income taxes on fourteen years of gains. That's another thirteen thousand dollars we have to scrape together for taxes in April.


Three days later.
Your father called me, Marcus. I know what happened. But before we talk about where you go from here, you need to understand what you actually destroyed.
A 529 plan isn't a locked chest in a vault. It is an investment engine—underlying total market index funds, equities, and bond ladders.

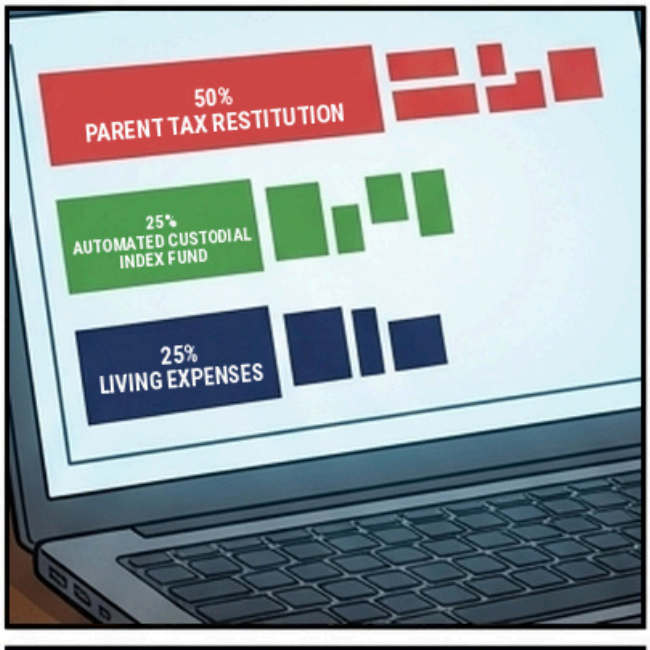

Your parents only deposited twenty-five thousand dollars out of pocket over fourteen years. Disciplined compound interest turned it into over fifty thousand.
DEPOSITED $25,000 → GREW TO $50,000+


Sportsbooks take an eight to ten percent house edge, called the vig. Over time, negative expected value guarantees you go broke. But in the broad stock market, you are buying ownership in real human production, which averages eight to ten percent annual long-term growth.
Twenty-five thousand doubled just from time? Without guessing on anything?


That is the power of ownership, Marcus. Let today sink in. We will take this one step at a time.


Three days later.
David, I saw how Marcus looked at those equations. He has an analytical mind that was fed to an algorithm. With your permission, I want to mentor him one-on-one.
DEPOSITED $25,000
GREW TO $50,000+
Marcus... Arthur called. He offered to take you under his wing and teach you how investing works.
KNOCK KNOCK
Really? When can I go see him? I want to fix this.

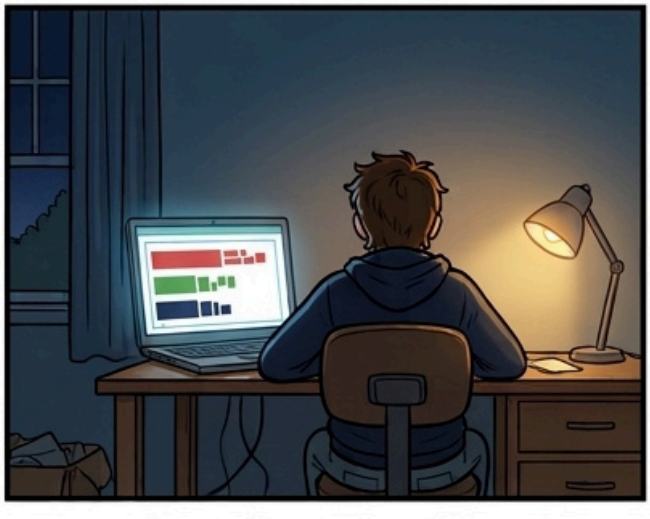




ARTHUR

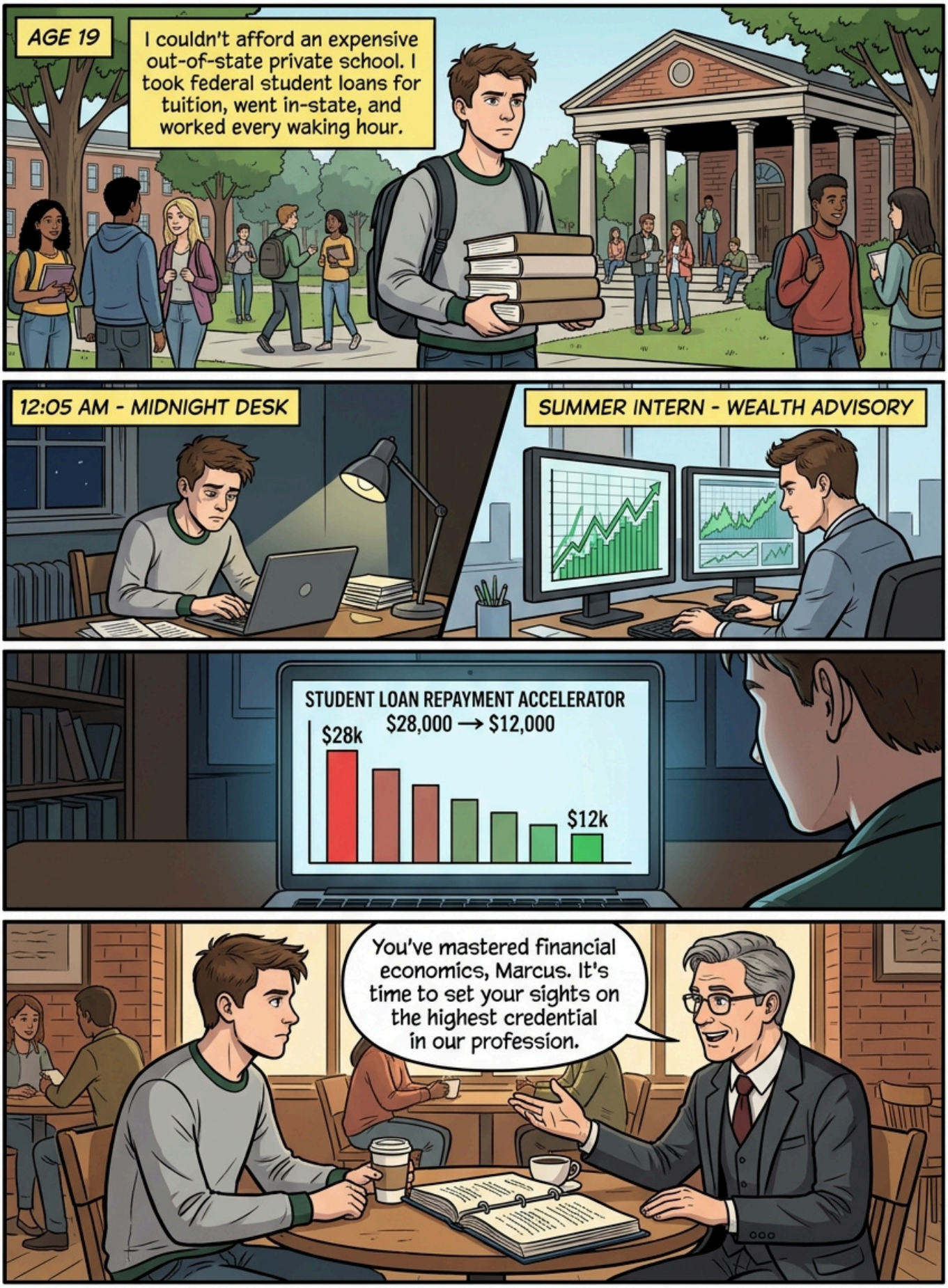
"You are fifteen. You have three years of high school, four years of college, and three years in the workforce to age twenty-five. You will repay your parents' tax penalties, work through school, and be debt-free by twenty-five."



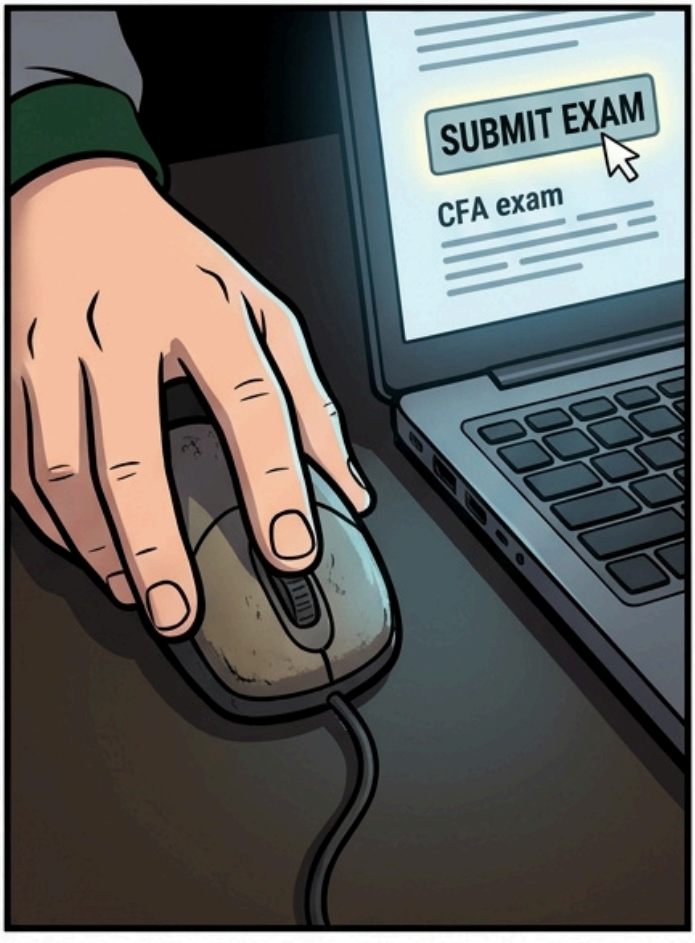


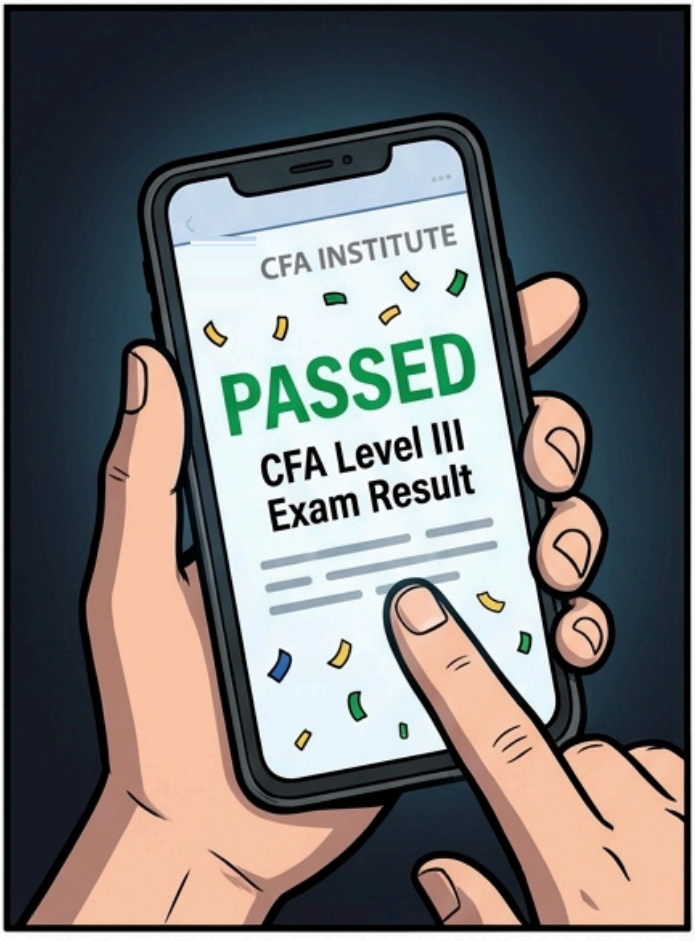


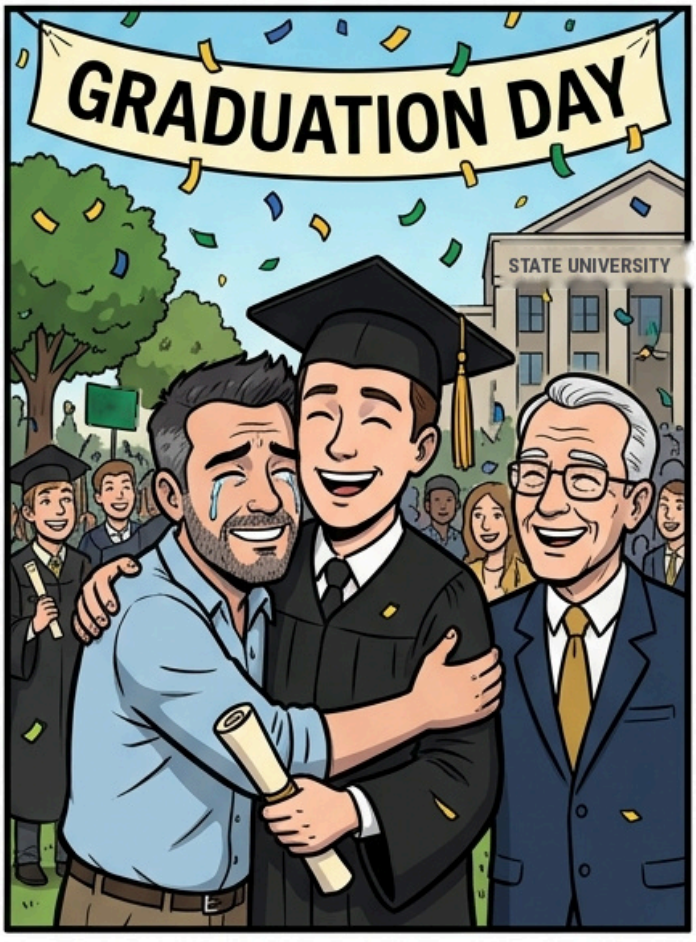

AGE 16
While my friends were driving around town on Friday nights, I was working thirty hours a week over commercial dishwashers.
WEEKLY EARNINGS: $240.00
TRANSFERRED TO DAD: $120.00
That covers another five hundred on the IRS payment, Mom.
Thank you, Marcus.
PORTFOLIO: $1,420.00
(INDEX AUTO-INVEST ACTIVE)


AGE 19
I couldn't afford an expensive out-of-state private school. I took federal student loans for tuition, went in-state, and worked every waking hour.
12:05 AM - MIDNIGHT DESK
SUMMER INTERN - WEALTH ADVISORY
STUDENT LOAN REPAYMENT ACCELERATOR
$28,000 → $12,000
$28k
$12k
You've mastered financial economics, Marcus. It's time to set your sights on the highest credential in our profession.

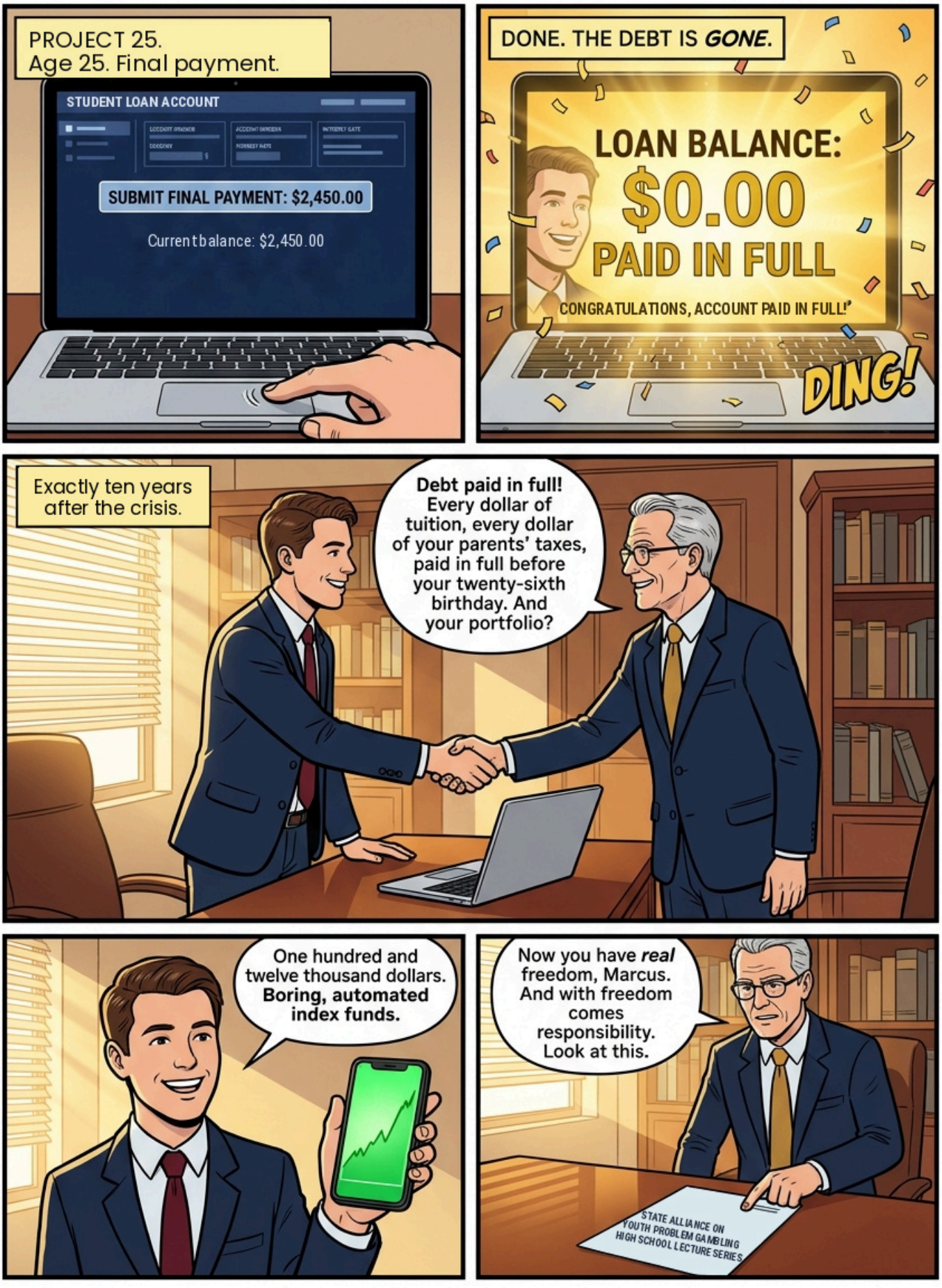

AGE 22
1:00 AM
ETHICS
QUANTITATIVE ANALYSIS
PORTFOLIO THEORY
The Chartered Financial Analyst charter. Three grueling levels. Fewer than half pass the first one. Ethics, portfolio theory, quantitative analysis.


SUBMIT EXAM
CFA exam


CFA INSTITUTE
PASSED
CFA Level III
Exam Result


GRADUATION DAY
STATE UNIVERSITY

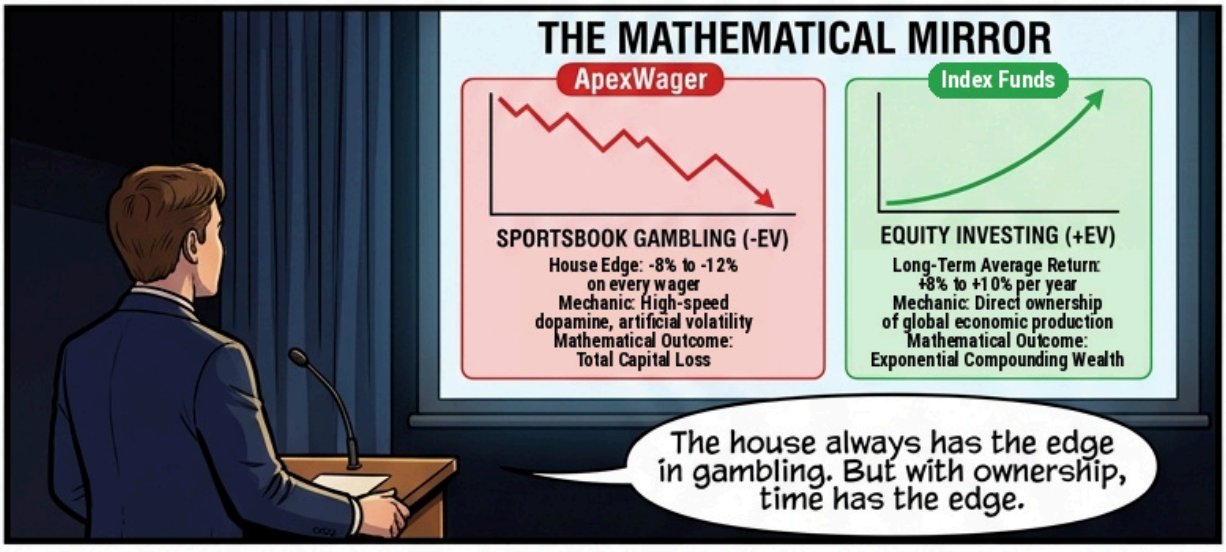

TEN YEARS AFTER THE CRISIS.
Exactly ten years... Let's do this.
MERRIWICK WEALTH
Look at you, Marcus. CFA charterholder, associate analyst at a major fund, and standing tall.
HUG!
Ten years ago, I thought my life was over in this room.
We all make mistakes, Marcus. You fixed it.
You gave me a roadmap when I only had shame.
Today is the final day...
CLICK
...of Project 25.


PROJECT 25.
Age 25. Final payment.
STUDENT LOAN ACCOUNT
SUBMIT FINAL PAYMENT: $2,450.00
Current balance: $2,450.00
DONE. THE DEBT IS GONE.
LOAN BALANCE:
$0.00
PAID IN FULL
CONGRATULATIONS, ACCOUNT PAID IN FULL!
DING!
Exactly ten years after the crisis.
Debt paid in full! Every dollar of tuition, every dollar of your parents' taxes, paid in full before your twenty-sixth birthday. And your portfolio?
One hundred and twelve thousand dollars. Boring, automated index funds.
Now you have real freedom, Marcus. And with freedom comes responsibility. Look at this.
STATE ALLIANCE ON YOUTH PROBLEM GAMBLING
HIGH SCHOOL LECTURE SERIES


Students, please welcome back an alumnus, Chartered Financial Analyst Marcus Arthur Merriwick.
CLAP! CLAP! CLAP!


I know what's in your pockets right now.
I know the group chats with the parlay slips, the bonus bets, and the hype about turning twenty bucks into a down payment on a car.


bzzt


THE MATHEMATICAL MIRROR
ApexWager
SPORTSBOOK GAMBLING (-EV)
House Edge: -8% to -12% on every wager
Mechanic: High-speed dopamine, artificial volatility
Mathematical Outcome: Total Capital Loss
Index Funds
EQUITY INVESTING (+EV)
Long-Term Average Return: +8% to +10% per year
Mechanic: Direct ownership of global economic production
Mathematical Outcome: Exponential Compounding Wealth
The house always has the edge in gambling. But with ownership, time has the edge.


The sportsbooks spend billions to make you believe you're one buzzer-beater away from freedom.
But true freedom isn't built on a lucky night. It's built on owning productive assets and letting time do the work.


Hey... Mr. Marcus. I... I lost five hundred dollars of my summer paycheck last week. I was about to chase it tonight on an offshore credit line to win it back.
Delete the app. Walk inside, tell your parents the truth, and start putting that paycheck into an index fund. The market takes time, but it never cheats the math.
DELETE 'APEXWAGER' AND ALL ASSOCIATED DATA?
DELETE
DON'T PLAY THEIR ODDS. OWN THE ASSETS. CHOOSE THE LONG PLAY.